

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Topic boundary and source matrix

OWNER: society, daily life, knowledge, religion and arts in the Gupta age

TOPIC 20 RETAINS: rulers, campaigns, offices, grants machinery and decline

SOURCES: Smriti | literature | inscriptions | coins | Faxian | art | archaeology

TEXT -> norm / imagination; INSCRIPTION -> selected public actor

TRAVELLER -> situated observation; MATERIAL -> practice with dating limits

METHOD: use at least two source classes and state each limitation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: Varna, jati and exclusion

VARNA -> normative four-fold macro-model

JATI / OCCUPATION -> numerous local and professional identities

STATUS CLAIM -> genealogy, office, patronage and Sanskritic idiom

EXCLUSION -> Chandala evidence, occupational stigma and spatial distance

MOBILITY and hierarchy coexisted.

RULE: one Smriti norm or Faxian passage cannot become a uniform all-India census.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Family, women and property

PATRILINEAL / PATRIARCHAL NORM -> dominant prescriptive frame

MARRIAGE / INHERITANCE -> text-specific and socially varied

STRIDHANA -> recognized category with differing control and succession rules

WOMEN'S AGENCY -> queens, donors, workers and literary representations

LIMIT: elite visibility does not prove general equality.

TRAP: Mitakshara and Dayabhaga are later schools, not Gupta legal codes.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Village, labour, craft and urban life

VILLAGE -> cultivators + land + taxes + vishti + household production

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food / fibre / revenue

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TOWN -> artisans + merchants + guild-linked groups + markets + sacred institutions

MANDASOR SILK WEAVERS -> migration, corporate identity and patronage

VERDICT: agrarian surplus and urban craft networks interacted, but regionally unevenly.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Faxian and daily-life reconstruction

FAXIAN c. 399-414 CE -> Buddhist pilgrimage purpose

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monasteries, routes, selected customs and Chandala passage

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valuable near-contemporary social and religious observations

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LIMITS: itinerary + audience + translation + silence + idealisation

USE: corroborate with inscriptions, texts and archaeology; never quote as a census.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Education, Sanskrit and multilingualism

COURTS + BRAHMANICAL CENTRES + MONASTERIES + TEACHER-PUPIL NETWORKS

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Sanskrit prestige in kavya, prashasti, theology and science

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Prakrits, regional speech and local inscriptions continue

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SANSKRITISATION = adoption + negotiation + local adaptation

NOT: one royal language law, universal literacy or extinction of other languages.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Literature and genre map

KAVYA / DRAMA -> Kalidasa and courtly aesthetic worlds

LEXICOGRAPHY -> Amarasimha / Amarakosha tradition

PURANIC TEXTS -> layered redaction and devotional-cosmological synthesis

SMRITI -> prescriptive law and social norm

BUDDHIST / JAIN WRITING -> continuing intellectual plurality

RULE: secure work and genre are stronger than later court-biography legends.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Mathematics, astronomy and metallurgy

499 CE -> ARYABHATIYA: computation, astronomy, pi and earth-rotation argument

6th c. -> VARAHAMIHIRA: post-main-Gupta continuation

628 CE -> BRAHMAGUPTA: explicitly post-Gupta chronology

MEHRAULI IRON PILLAR -> large wrought iron and corrosion resistance

CAUTION: place value != sole invention of zero; King Chandra identification debated.

VERDICT: cumulative specialist traditions, not isolated miracle claims.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: Religious plurality and patronage

VAISHNAVA + SHAIVA + SHAKTA Puranic formations

BUDDHIST monasteries, images and pilgrimage networks

JAIN communities, images and sites

ROYAL COURTS + regional rulers + guilds + households + monks -> patrons

Udayagiri joins royal Vaishnava imagery with wider sacred presence.

RULE: plural patronage was unequal and strategic; it is not modern secular neutrality.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Temples, sculpture, painting and Ajanta

TEMPLES -> Sanchi 17 | Udayagiri | Bhitargaon | Deogarh

SCULPTURE -> Mathura and Sarnath materials, modelling and robe conventions

PAINTING -> Ajanta narrative, courtly, devotional and workshop production

ARCHITECTURAL TREND -> garbhagriha + porch/mandapa + emerging superstructure

OWNERSHIP LIMIT: major fifth-century Ajanta phase is Vakataka-context.

RULE: name object/site, form, date, patronage and attribution caution.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Golden Age and social distribution

CLASSICAL ACHIEVEMENT

literature + science + iconic art + structural temples + prestige language

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TEST DISTRIBUTION

region | class | caste | gender | labour | literacy | patronage

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COUNTER-EVIDENCE: exclusion, vishti, patriarchal norms and elite archives

VERDICT: culturally consequential and enduring, but neither uniform nor universally golden.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Culture answer spine

OPEN: social-cultural companion to Gupta polity, reconstructed through mixed sources

BODY 1: hierarchy + household + women + labour

BODY 2: village-town and patronage institutions

BODY 3: language + literature + science + religion + arts

EACH EXAMPLE: claim -> named evidence -> significance -> limit

QUALIFY: chronology, regional ownership, source genre and social distribution

VERDICT: classical production emerged from plural but unequal social worlds.